

Donor Recognition Outreach Study

A University of Oregon Advancement Leadership Internship project evaluating donor recognition outreach and developing an engagement metric tool to guide future stewardship strategy.

● Project Overview

During my UO Advancement Leadership Internship, I worked on a longitudinal study of a donor recognition outreach effort for long-term Loyalty Circle donors. The project combined outreach activity data, giving indicators, and engagement outcomes to evaluate whether the campaign reached its intended audience, how donor response varied across segments, and what future stewardship efforts could learn from those patterns.

The work culminated in a project report and a reusable engagement metric tool that is still being used to help shape outreach efforts. The public summary here describes the study design, metric, and findings at a high level. The original working report is not linked because donor-facing and internal advancement materials should be reviewed before public distribution.

460

Personalized outreach messages sent to long-term Loyalty Circle donors.

68%

Open rate used to evaluate initial donor reach and message reception.

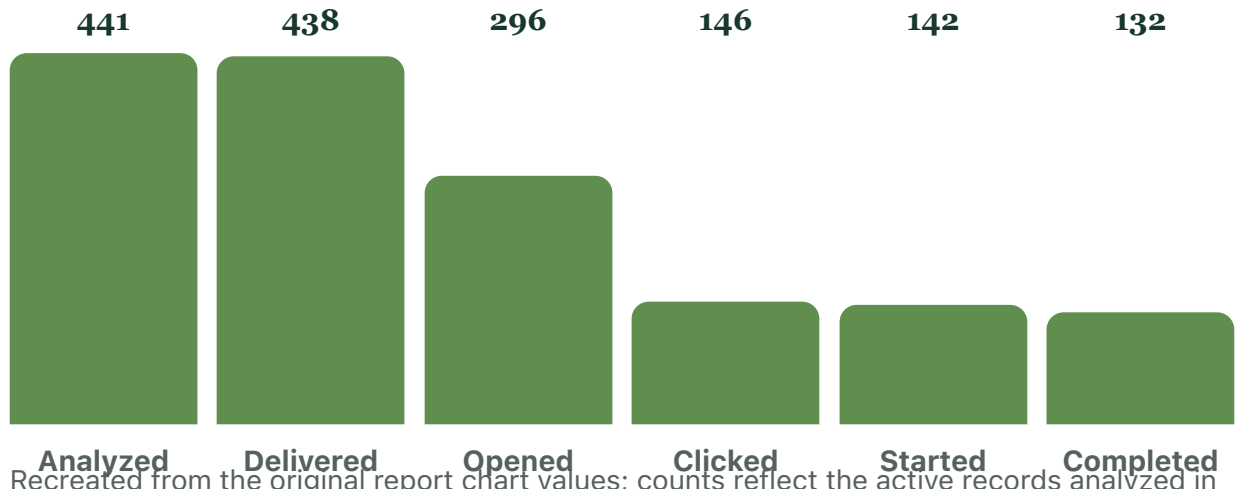
132

Donors completed the video activity, helping identify the link-click conversion point.

● Campaign Reach

Before the engagement index was applied, the first question was whether the outreach actually reached donors and where participation narrowed. The largest drop happened between opening the message and clicking through to the video, making the click-through step the clearest point for strategic improvement.

Participation by Activity Phase



Recreated from the original report chart values; counts reflect the active records analyzed in the study.

• Engagement Index

The engagement index translated outreach-platform behaviors into a practical score that could flag delivery problems, distinguish passive opens from active engagement, and compare response patterns across donor segments.

< 0

Delivery issue

0-1

Did not engage

1

Opened message

1-2

Engaged partially

2

Completed activity

> 2

Substantive engagement

-1

Delivery
problem

1

Opened
message

0.25 each

Clicked, started,
watched 50%,
finished

+1 each

Repeat views,
shares,
downloads,
replies

• What the Index Revealed

The engagement index made the study more useful than a simple completion-rate report. Several donors who did not fully complete the video still scored in the substantive-engagement range because they shared, downloaded, replied, or returned to the activity. That helped identify interest that a completion-only metric would have treated as a weak response.

> 2

Substantive Engagement Beyond Completion

Decimal scores above 2 flagged donors who had not completed every video stage but still took additional high-intent actions.

2.07

A Segment Worth Studying

Giving Level 4 had an average engagement score above 2 despite a lower completion rate than nearby levels.

97%

The Click Was the Hinge

Among recipients who clicked the link, nearly all started the video, and most of those who started went on to complete it.

10%

No-Click Gap

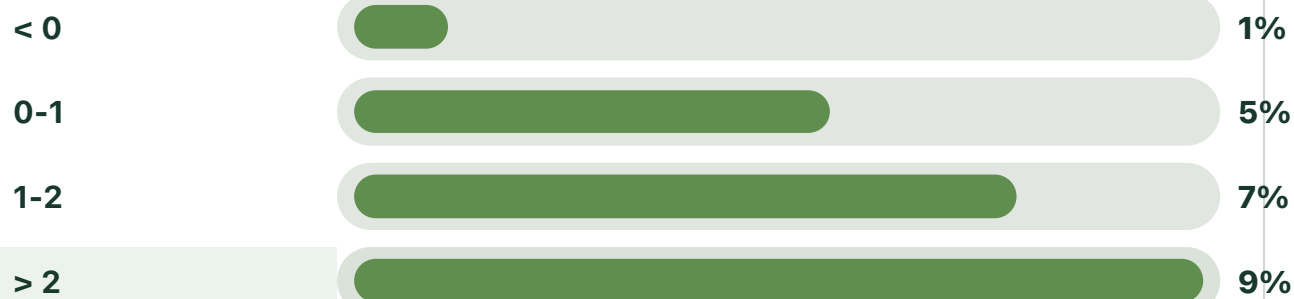
The no-click group had an average gift-size change that was less than 10% of the clicked group, despite having more individuals.

Average Engagement Score by Giving Level



Scores above 2 indicate substantive engagement. Highlighted rows show giving levels that crossed that threshold. Level numbers replace the original giving categories.

Later Activity Rose With Engagement Score



Activity-rate change by engagement-score group; the highest engagement group also showed the largest activity and volunteer change in the report.

• Recommendations

The study recommended refining donor segmentation so outreach strategy is informed by behavioral signals, not giving level alone. Engagement patterns such as opening, clicking, repeat viewing, sharing, downloading, and replying can help identify which donors are receptive to particular forms of recognition and which audiences may respond better to a different message, format, or timing.

It also recommended using the engagement index as a comparison tool across future outreach efforts, pairing it with long-term dashboard tracking, and testing smaller targeted recognition projects that are designed around donor response patterns rather than broad stewardship categories.